longevity; if I can share practical examples with a young player who wants to learn, without the hierarchical formalities of being a coach, I'm more than happy to do so.

Basic guidelines, beyond the complexities of technique? Never over complicate. Don't make a simple game very hard. Apply yourself, ingrain what you believe to be the best of you. With clarity comes consistency, but always remember that sport can be contradictory. Stuff just happens. There's nothing you can do about the saddest fact of a cricketer's life, that you wish you knew, at twenty-one, what you know at thirty-five.

I'm not quite at the stage where I'm sitting in front of the fire in fond reminiscence of the old days and the old ways, but I am seeing the game through a different lens. As England captain I consciously refused to talk up an opposition player, or team, beyond the bland niceties of a press conference that no one takes the slightest notice of.

I was desperate not to fail. I wanted to score more runs than anyone else. If that meant keeping my true thoughts to myself, then so be it. Now, though, I have the freedom to be frank. Instead of viewing someone like Virat Kohli as a rival, I see him for what he is, a master of his trade. He no longer represents a danger, a point of potentially unflattering comparison.

I recognize the resilience it took for him to overcome his early struggles in England. I am in awe of his ability to compartmentalize a life that is not his own. But most of all, I can enjoy the beauty of his batting, the extraordinary way in which he responds to the evolving demands of a run chase in one-day cricket. The placement of his shots, and the consistency of his technique, are stunning. I hadn't realized until now how good he is.

I've never been one for quantifying a player purely on the evidence of the record books. That doesn't mean I have any less respect or admiration for those bygone heroes who had occasionally to make their runs on uncovered wickets, or on imperfect pitches without the insurance of a protective helmet. I simply prefer to make my judgements through personal experience. On that basis, and with apologies for omitting Morne Morkel and Ishant Sharma, the bowlers who probably caused me the most difficulty, I consider Ricky Ponting, Jacques Kallis and Brian Lara to be the three standout players of my generation.

Rod Marsh, who took charge of the England Academy for four years, up to 2005, used to tell a story about Ponting and the 'bouncer sessions' he starred in at the indoor centre at the Adelaide Oval when he did the same